Systems Analysis

What is conflict analysis?

Conflict analysis is a practice-oriented analysis of the actors, causes, factors, context and dynamics of a conflict as well as the identification of (possible) entry points for program design and peacebuilding strategies.

Conflict analysis is never an end or a goal in itself. It is only the first crucial step in designing a peacebuilding project or program. Conflict analysis gives us clarity on the main actors we want to engage with and the key conflict factors we want to address. It offers crucial information about the likely impact of our intervention on the conflict and peace dynamics.

Elements of good analysis

There are a number of different tools for conducting conflict analysis. Given this, the question arises what are the key or "must have" characteristics or "nice to have" characteristics of a good conflict analysis.

The Reflecting on Peace Practice Study, which we have looked at throughout our work together, has found that the following characteristics are considered key and "must have" for any conflict analysis:

- Identifying and prioritizing the key driving factors of conflict (KDFs) and their relationships
- Identifying main actors and stakeholders
- Considering regional and international dimensions
- Understanding the relationships and dynamics between conflict factors and actors, and how they have been evolving over time

Based on this, the Systems Analysis Tool for doing conflict analysis was developed.

Systems Analysis Overview

Systems Analysis views conflicts as systems. A system is an interconnected set of elements that is coherently organized in a way that achieves a 'purpose'. Conflicts do not exist in isolation and considering the system of the conflict is essential for proper analysis. Systems thinking, and Systemic Conflict Analysis, enables us to understand how different elements in conflicts relate to and influence each other.

There are three main parts of a system:

- Elements/factors
- Interconnections
- Purpose

Steps in Systems Analysis

In Systems Analysis, different key questions and steps will help you to organize data about the conflict and identify the Key Driving Factors (KDFs) of the conflict.

Key Driving Factors are factors or dynamics without which the conflict would not exist or would be significantly different.

The steps in systems analysis are:

1) Gather data, collect other people's analyses, read literature, etc.

2) Sort data: what have you got, what is usable/not?

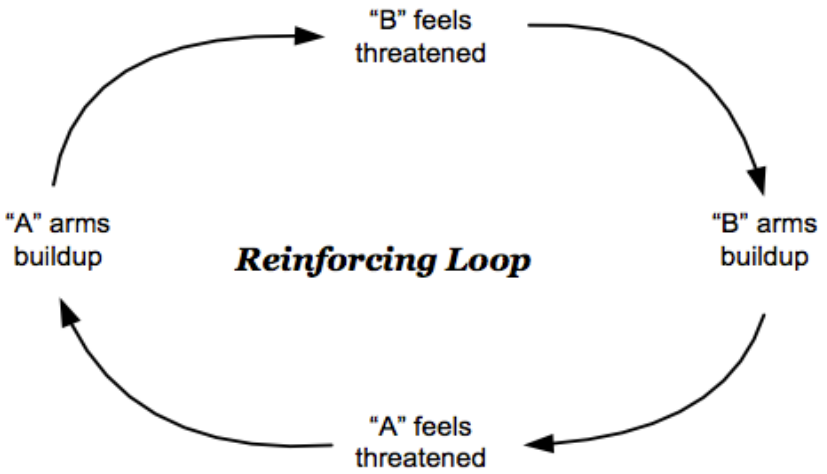
3) Use the three-box model to sort information

The three-box model helps to identify and prioritize the factors against peace/for conflict and factors for peace and the main actors and stakeholders. The three-box model helps to keep the process of conflict analysis simple and pragmatic while taking into account the real complexity of the conflict situation and organizational routines.

Forces for Peace /Against Conflict ->		**Forces for Conflict <- Against peace**	**Key Actors**
What are the forces in the situation that exist now that can be built upon to promote movement towards peace? What currently connects people across conflict lines? How do people cooperate? Who exercises leadership for peace and how? *Note: These are not things you want to exist or that you would like to see—they must be true now.*	**P E A C E**	What are factors are working against peace or for conflict? What factors, issues or elements are causing conflict and/or dividing people, and how?	Which individuals or groups in the situation are in a position to strongly influence the conflict negatively? Who can decide against peace? Which individuals or groups in the situation are in a position to strongly influence the conflict positively? Who can decide for peace? *Note: These are not necessarily people who may be program targets/participants, such as women, youth, or religious leaders.* *We maybe interested in engaging with those groups, but they are not always "key" in the situation.*

4) Among the factors against peace, identify which ones (5 - 6 maximum) are Key Driving Factors of conflict
5) Create conflict-trees for the KDFs you have identified.
6) Begin creating loop diagrams based on conflict-trees.

The loop diagram illustrates how the elements and key driving factors relate to each other, and creating dynamics like a viscous or virtuous cycle. We will practice this during the workshop. An example is included below:



Tips for Analysis

- Conflict analysis should be ongoing.
- Do not confuse conflict analysis with context analysis – focus on understanding the dynamics of the conflict.
- Remember to base your intervention strategy on the insights from the conflict analysis.
- Make the conflict analysis more explicit for you and others, even if you have a long experience of the conflict.
- Remember that there is not one objective and true analysis of the conflict; analysis is always influenced by the perspectives of the individuals or groups who conduct them.
- Adjust or combine conflict analysis tools if needed.
- Do not only identify the factors, but also their interrelation and dynamics.
- Be aware of and try to avoid biased and narrow analyses (for instance; just focusing on one sector).
- Tips and hints for identifying KDFs:
    - Use nouns or noun phrases rather than verbs.
    - State factors as things that can be scaled up or down (e.g. "level of", "amount of")
    - Actors and sectors are not factors. Their behavior could be.
    - Combine factors that represent similar information, without being too general.
    - Focus on the most important variables.
    - Test: If the factor was increased or decreased significantly, would that have a big effect on the issue or situation?